

Photographs by RAJWANT RAWAT

"While the Vajpayee regime believed in encouraging growth through building infrastructure, for the Modi government, redistribution of wealth is as important"

– ILA PATNAIK

Janmabhoomi. But no party can remain in power continuously on one emotive issue. Yes, we do believe in cultural nationalism, but apart from this, political consistency, dedication, strategy, organisation-strengthening, capacity-building and social equations too are important to the party. Hence, while tracking the journey of the BJP, besides the importance of its leaders, I have laid equal emphasis on other things like how the party organisation is structured and the people's involvement. It is the cumulative effect of everything.

Q. The book doesn't delve in depth into the Hindutva narrative. Is it deliberate?

Yadav: When we say '*Sarve Bhavantu Sukhinah*' (may all be happy), it is not just a philosophical thing for us. It means ensuring the welfare of all, especially the poor. Secondly, the faith may be individual, but philosophies can be different. Even within Hindutva, there are several philosophical schools like Nyaya, Vaisheshik, Yoga or Sankhya. There is no singularity of thought; even atheists like Charvaka find a place. Philosophically, our uniqueness lies in accepting different things, but our focus remains cultural identity. We are part of an ancient national culture. So, a larger definition of Hindutva is its acceptability, taking it as a way of life, believing it to be environment-friendly, assigning it a scientific attitude, and that it changes with the times while retaining its core identity and values... Hindutva is not a rigid thing. There is a difference between unity and uniformity. Hindutva is for unity, not for uniformity.

Q. Except when it comes to a Uniform Civil Code...

Yadav: Even in the civil code, within a single Hindu society, there are different rituals. So, should everyone follow the same traditions in marriage? No! This cannot happen. But, Article 14 of the Constitution, which is about the right to equality, must be applied equally. Overall, there must be consensus on the issue related to human dignity.

Q. Was there a change in economic direction when Narendra Modi assumed power compared to the Vajpayee era?

Ila Patnaik: One needs to see what the objective of the BJP in economics and governance was. One objective was to raise the standard of living of the people irrespective of caste, community, region or class. For that, the party believes you need both growth and redistribution of wealth. The Vajpayee government's policies focused on creating the infrastructure that could raise it. So, for example, rural roads—under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana—was one of the first very successful cases of infrastructure building. As also telecom reforms, including privatisation, which was basically spurring growth by reducing the misallocation of resources. Now, when you come to Modi 1.0, the emphasis is on redistribution apart from infrastructure—better governance, better and targeted delivery. Banking the unbanked through Jan Dhan is a good example. Also, plugging the leakage in welfare schemes and cleansing the system. This was done by eliminating intermediaries through direct benefit transfer mechanisms.

Q. How would you describe the BJP's economic philosophy?

Patnaik: To get economic growth in the system, the approach was to have a market-based economy but with the government being a regulator and infrastructure-builder, which would create the conditions and the environment for people to add value by producing and organising themselves efficiently to contribute to the economy. They are not saying everything will be done by the State, like in the '60s and '70s, whether it is hotels or watches or airlines. They believe the private sector can manage these more efficiently. What they want the State to do is to bring regulation like an efficient tax system as with GST in which the government tried to make India one market and get rid of all the octrois and different taxes. Or the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code that broke the nexus between banks and industrialists that had bred corruption.

Q. The Modi government came to power promising minimum government, but when accused of being a '*suit-boot sarkar*' veered towards becoming a messiah of the poor?

Yadav: I believe that the biggest tragedy of the BJP is that it has been painted as a party of urban upper caste people—of business tycoons and the rich. That we